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ARTICLE

Defense Department Decision Reignites The Mormon-Christian Debate





BY PNW STAFF JUNE 08, 2026

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A controversy has erupted following recent changes by the U.S. Department of Defense to its religious affiliation system. The Pentagon reduced its list of recognized religious designations from more than 200 categories to just 31, arguing that the move would simplify chaplain support and make it easier to meet the spiritual needs of service members.

The changes have generated criticism from a variety of religious groups, but one decision has drawn particular attention: The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints was not grouped under the military's broad Christian category in the same way many traditional Christian denominations were.

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Predictably, the decision sparked debate. Members of the LDS Church often identify themselves as Christians, pointing to their belief in Jesus Christ, His death on the cross, His resurrection, and His role as Savior. Many outside observers therefore wonder why evangelical Protestants, Catholics, Eastern Orthodox believers, and many other Christian traditions generally do not classify Mormonism as part of historic Christianity.

This discussion is not primarily about sincerity. Most Christians would acknowledge that many Mormons are moral, family-oriented, and deeply committed to their faith. The disagreement is theological. The issue is not whether Mormons talk about Jesus, but whether they mean the same thing Christians have historically meant when they use terms such as God, Jesus, salvation, heaven, revelation, and scripture.

This is where terminology becomes critically important.



A Muslim may say he differs dramatically from Christians while assigning very different meanings to those words.

Understanding of God often use identical

Below are ten major doctrinal differences that explain why most Christian denominations do not regard Mormonism as part of historic Christianity.

1. The Nature of God

Historic Christianity teaches that there is one eternal God who has always existed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. God is uncreated, eternal, and unique.

Mormon theology teaches that God the Father was once a man who progressed to godhood. This concept fundamentally alters the Christian understanding of God's eternal nature. Christianity teaches that God has always been God and never became God.

2. The Trinity

Christians believe in one God existing eternally in three persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Mormonism rejects the traditional doctrine of the Trinity. Instead, it teaches that the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost are three distinct beings united in purpose rather than one divine essence. This difference alone has historically been viewed by Christian theologians as placing Mormonism outside orthodox Christianity.

3. The Identity of Jesus Christ

Christians believe Jesus is the eternal Son of God who has existed forever with the Father.

Mormon teaching presents Jesus as a spirit child of Heavenly Father. Traditional Christianity rejects the idea that Christ was created or generated as a spirit being. Christians view Jesus as eternally divine rather than one spirit offspring among many.

4. The Existence of Many Gods

Christianity teaches monotheism--there is only one God.

Mormon theology has historically taught that exalted humans may become gods and that other gods exist. While LDS leaders often emphasize worship of only one God, the broader theological framework differs dramatically from the biblical doctrine of one eternal, unique God.



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5. Human Destiny

Christianity teaches that believers are adopted as God's children and will share in His kingdom.

Mormon doctrine includes the concept of exaltation, where faithful adherents may eventually attain godlike status. Historic Christianity has consistently rejected the idea that human beings can become gods in any literal sense.

6. Scripture

Christians recognize the Bible as the final and authoritative written revelation of God.

Mormons accept the Bible but also recognize additional scriptures, including the Book of Mormon, Doctrine and Covenants, and Pearl of Great Price. This creates a fundamentally different authority structure for doctrine and practice.

7. Continuing Revelation

Christianity teaches that God's revelation was completed through Christ and His apostles, with Scripture serving as the final authority.

The LDS Church teaches that modern prophets receive ongoing revelation that can clarify or expand doctrine. This concept of continuing authoritative revelation stands in contrast to the traditional Christian view.

8. Salvation

Historic Christianity teaches salvation by grace through faith in Christ, resulting in good works as evidence of genuine faith.

Mormon theology places significantly greater emphasis on ordinances, temple rituals, covenant keeping, and faithful obedience as components of the path toward exaltation. While both groups use the language of grace, they often mean different things by it.

9. The Fall of Man

Christians generally v

Mormon theology often speaks of the fall in more positive terms, seeing it as a necessary step that enabled human progression and God's plan for mortal existence. This produces a very different understanding of humanity's condition and need for redemption.

10. The Origin of the Church

Christianity teaches that Christ established His church through the apostles in the first century.

Mormonism teaches a "Great Apostasy," claiming that true Christianity disappeared from the earth and was restored through Joseph Smith in the nineteenth century. This means Mormonism does not merely differ from Christianity on secondary issues; it challenges the legitimacy of virtually all Christian history between the apostles and Joseph Smith.

These differences explain why the overwhelming majority of Protestant, Catholic, and Orthodox scholars have historically concluded that Mormonism represents a separate religious tradition rather than another branch of Christianity. That conclusion is not rooted in hostility toward individual Mormons. It is rooted in the belief that Mormon theology redefines foundational Christian doctrines regarding God, Christ, salvation, revelation, and the nature of the church itself.

The recent military classification controversy has therefore reopened a debate that has existed for nearly two centuries. Mormons sincerely identify as Christians because they believe Jesus Christ is central to their faith. Historic Christianity, however, has generally responded that the question is not whether Jesus is mentioned, but whether the Jesus being described is the same Jesus revealed in Scripture and confessed by the church throughout its history.

That distinction may seem technical to outsiders. Yet for Christians, it is one of the most important theological questions imaginable.

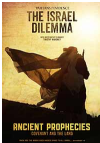
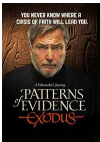
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